



MOTION on NOTICE

Submitted at the Regular Park Board Meeting on May 25, 2026

Prohibition and Restriction of Motorized Personal Watercraft in Burrard Inlet

SUBMITTED BY: Commissioner Digby

WHEREAS

1. The mandate of the Vancouver Board of Parks and Recreation includes the protection of shoreline ecosystems, marine biodiversity, public beaches, and safe recreational access to Vancouver's waterfront;
2. Burrard Inlet has experienced a notable increase in sightings of cetaceans and marine wildlife in recent years, including orca, humpback, and grey whales, reflecting both ecological recovery efforts and the growing environmental significance of local marine habitat;
3. Scientific and public concern continues to grow regarding the impacts of high-speed motorized personal watercraft, including Jet Skis and Sea Doos, on marine mammals and coastal ecosystems through noise pollution, wake disturbance, shoreline intrusion, and the heightened risk of wildlife harassment or collision;
4. A widely publicized whale strike incident in British Columbia waters on May 4, 2026 intensified public awareness regarding the risks posed by fast-moving personal watercraft operating in sensitive marine environments;
5. Personal watercraft are uniquely capable of operating at high speeds in shallow near-shore waters, intertidal zones, and ecologically sensitive areas that are increasingly being prioritized for biodiversity restoration, eelgrass protection, and habitat enhancement initiatives;
6. Vancouver's beaches and waterfront parks are among the city's most important public ecological and recreational assets, and growing public concern has been expressed regarding excessive noise, unsafe operation, and environmental disturbance associated with personal watercraft activity near swimming beaches and shoreline parks;
7. Other jurisdictions, including Sydney, Washington State, Hawaii, Toronto, and Quebec have implemented motorized personal watercraft exclusion zones, speed restrictions, and/or enhanced enforcement measures to protect whales and/or improve public safety; and
8. The Park Board's existing 2019 approved "On Water" policy primarily addresses non-motorized recreational uses and does not currently provide policy direction or advocacy guidance respecting the environmental and safety impacts of motorized personal watercraft in Burrard Inlet;



THEREFORE BE IT RESOLVED

- A. THAT The Vancouver Board of Parks and Recreation formally adopt a policy position advocating for the prohibition or significant restriction of high-speed recreational motorized personal watercraft, including Jet Skis and Sea Doos, within Burrard Inlet and adjacent near-shore waters surrounding Vancouver parks and beaches;
- B. Park Board staff be directed to report back on measures available within Park Board jurisdiction to discourage or restrict the launching, staging, and operation of motorized personal watercraft from Park Board-managed facilities, including signage, public education, launch conditions, and potential amendments to relevant policies or permits;
- C. The Chair of the Park Board be directed to advocate to relevant federal and regional authorities, including Transport Canada, Fisheries and Oceans Canada, Vancouver Fraser Port Authority, and the Vancouver Police Department Marine Unit, for stronger regulation of motorized personal watercraft activity in Burrard Inlet in order to improve marine wildlife protection, reduce shoreline disturbance, and enhance public safety; and
- D. The Park Board further call upon senior governments and marine regulatory agencies to prioritize Burrard Inlet as an urban marine conservation and stewardship zone, recognizing its growing importance for marine biodiversity, climate resilience, and public ecological education.